foreign travel.[90] However, for all its sheen, it should be remembered that the railways did not introduce the concept of travel in India and that it wasn't present in many of the corridors of the Great Indian Migration Wave—where carts, steamers and motor transport operated. The railways were not the most important institution in the lives of migrant workers. That distinction fell to the post office.

The Post Office of India, formally established in 1854, rapidly wove its way into the lives of migrant workers across the subcontinent.[91] Letters and telegrams were useful, but not so much for the illiterate migrant. It was the birth of the Indian postal money order in 1880 that dramatically changed the life of migrant workers by allowing a cheap, secure and reliable means of remittances. The money order was the first formal financial instrument used by the masses and was quickly lapped up in all the migration corridors within and outside India. It, however, posed a unique problem to the postal department in the initial years. Since most migrant workers were men, and remittance recipients were women, it was difficult to disburse cash from the regional post offices as prevailing gender norms restricted women's mobility. In 1884, the post office radically altered the money order system to provide home delivery of cash, a unique practice that survived until very recently. It also gave the postman in every village the position of being not just a harbinger of letters and news but also money. In the early 20th century, east Uttar Pradesh, the position of the postman was elevated to just below that of a policeman's, where he could exact 'a high price of undoing the straps of his money-order bag'.[92]

Compared to the railways, the postal department was unusually active in addressing migrants' concerns. Illiteracy was combated through innovative postal services. A class of professional letter writers emerged to assist remitters in filling up money order forms. Since 1896, thumbprints of payees were taken as marks of acknowledgment for the remitter. This slip was dubbed as a 'magic slip of paper' that for the first time served as an 'indisputable proof of payment' for labourers.[93] New types of money orders to make payments of rents also emerged. These postal innovations caught the attention of global media outlets. In 1898, an article in the *New York*